take me back to the start

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28866036.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Razz (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Once Upon a Time Fusion, Inspired by Once Upon a Time (TV), Angst, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, this is just a ouat au for adora's birthday, Birthday, Let Catra (She-Ra) Say Fuck, Adora Day

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by augustren

Summary

When Catra pulled the lever, she had no idea where the portal would take them.

A small town in Maine where everyone had no memory of Etheria was the last thing she expected.

OR: Catradora OUAT au where the alternate reality the portal brings them to is the town of Greyskull, where there are no princesses or magic or any memories of Etheria at all.

Notes

i was rewatching once upon a time and decided i would write a oneshot au for adora's bday bc why not

the title is from the scientist by coldplay

not everything lines up with canon because my fic my rules

enjoy! :)

See the end of the work for more notes

January 19th, Boston

The day was the same as it always was. Adora woke up, went to work, picked up a cupcake on the way home, and finished it off with making a shitty wish on a shitty candle from the dollar store.

This time, however, there was a knock at the door.

Adora couldn't think of who it could possibly be. She didn't have friends in the city and twenty two years on this lonely Earth taught her that she didn't have any family either.

Her wish remained the same, that she would find her family. But Adora was twenty two now, she knew better than to believe in wishes. Especially ones made on $2 candles on the cold countertop of her lonely apartment.

Hesitantly opening the door, Adora was greeted by the sight of a person she was most definitely *not* expecting.

There on her doorstep, standing a good few inches below her, was an old woman with thick grey hair and wearing more jewelry and robes than Adora had ever seen in her life.

"Mara!" The woman exclaimed, adjusting her glasses to stare at Adora as if she were an old friend.

“Do- Do I know you?” Surely whoever this woman was had the wrong apartment number. Adora had never seen this woman in her life, and she had no idea who Mara was.

“Oh, Mara. Don’t be silly!” The woman waved Adora’s question off, pushing past her into the apartment.

Adora blinked. Confused as ever, she shut the door and turned back to her unexpected guest.

“I’m not Mara!” She said to the woman now curiously inspecting the lone cupcake on the kitchen island. “And what are you doing here?”

The woman looked up to Adora, the sad look in her eyes magnified by round purple frames. She walked over to Adora, giving her a closer look.

“Ah, I see.” She sighed. “But you have to come with me!”

“I- What?” The more this woman talked, the more she didn’t make sense.

The woman below clicked her tongue furiously, opening the fridge and mumbling something about her disappointment in the lack of

pie.

“Who are you?” Adora asked. She tried not to raise her voice, but she was desperate and confused. This woman showed up at her door and pushed her way into the apartment like she knew Adora. And the more time that went by, the more foolish hope filled Adora’s head that maybe… maybe this woman was family.

The woman looked to Adora once more, her sad eyes looking at Adora with newfound understanding. Even if there were no wrinkles on her skin, her age showed in just her eyes.

“You don’t know Madame Razz yet, do you?” The woman asked. Adora shook her head, watching as the stranger looked disappointed before shaking her head and continuing as if nothing had happened. She gave Adora a soft smile. “Well, no worries. Now you do.”

Adora returned the smile despite herself. It was strange, having a stranger show up at her door and invite themselves in to wreak havoc on her apartment and it’s kitchen. But the company was nice. It was more kindness than Adora had seen from a stranger in years.

“I’m Adora.” She smiled, holding out her hand. Razz gave one look at the outstretched hand before bursting into laughter.

Confused and a little offended, Adora pulled her hand away after her failed attempt at a handshake. Was something wrong? What was Razz's deal with handshakes?

"I know that, silly." Razz chuckled like it was an inside joke between the two. Except that it wasn't, because Adora had never met this woman before in her life.

"But how? I-" Adora tripped over her words, not knowing what to think of having a complete stranger know her name. Razz was inspecting lamps and moving pillows when Adora finally got the words out. "You've never met me! How do you know me?"

Razz paused, dropping a throw pillow back on the couch. She tapped her chin in consideration, mumbling to herself.

"Sorry, dearie." She apologized. "Madame Razz forgets. But *you* have to remember!"

"Remember what?" Adora was asking questions to only get more questions. Madame Razz's answers were as vague and unhelpful as they could be.

"She-Ra!" Razz said, motioning to Adora as if she had something to do with it.

Adora looked to Razz, searching for any hint that this was a joke. She was concerned to find that this woman was deadly serious.

"You mean that show from the 80s?" Razz shook her head.

"It's not a show, It's you! You *are* She-Ra!" Razz had moved closer to Adora, placing her hands on Adora's shoulders and shaking them as if that would get Adora to remember that she was a character in an 80s cartoon.

It occurred to Adora that this woman could have an illness, Alzheimer's or something like it. Razz could have been separated from her family or lost somehow. And if Adora couldn't find her family, she could at least help Razz find hers.

"Where do you live?" Adora asked carefully. Razz looked confused before responding.

"Etheria, of course! We all did…. or we used to. It gets all muddled up sometimes." Razz thought it over for a moment before continuing. She shrugged. "But now we just live in Greyskull."

"Who's we?" Adora asked, the sound of Razz's cackles filling the air once more.

"Everyone! Bow, Glimmer, Swift Wind, Catra…"

Catra.

There was a sharp pain in Adora's chest at the sound of that name. It was so familiar but so… distant. But that was ridiculous, thinking she remembered someone who didn't even exist. It was probably just the memories of a childhood cartoon.

Adora was pulled back to reality, quite literally, when she noticed Razz had a firm grip on her arm and was trying to drag her to the door.

"We have to go!" Razz said like she had been in a hurry all along.

Adora knew she couldn't ask Razz any more questions. The answers were hardly answers, she knew she would get nowhere.

And so Adora let the stranger drag her all the way outside, reluctantly unlocking her red Volkswagen Beetle and driving away to a town she had never heard of before.

"And Swift Wind is…"

"Your horse! He's Madame Razz's favorite. Every time he comes to visit, he helps with pie." Razz sighs, a wistful look on her face as if recalling a fond memory. "It's been so long since he's visited."

As it turns out, Greyskull didn't show up on google maps or any other GPS app. Razz, however, insisted she knew the way and almost immediately began giving Adora directions. Adora figured Razz probably just got the wrong name or something. If all else failed, there was probably a shelter or crisis center where Adora could drop the stranger off if need be. Adora hoped it didn't have to come to that.

They were about thirty minutes into the car ride and Razz had wasted no time explaining to Adora everything about Etheria.

So far, Adora had learned that Glimmer and Bow were supposedly her best friends. Catra used to be, but was now with the Horde and Adora's alleged enemy. Adora asked how Razz knew all of this information. Apparently, Adora complained about Catra *a lot* . Mara was the She-Ra before Adora and seemingly very close to Razz. The old woman seemed to have a very special place in her heart for the horse, though.

And while Adora knew it was impossible, she couldn't help but be intrigued at how Razz talked about these people. For simple cartoon characters, they seemed to have a very dedicated backstory in Razz's mind. Adora could only wonder how someone could think of such things.

What was also strange to Adora was the fact that Madame Razz knew weirdly specific details about her. Razz knew her favorite pie flavor, how she acted when stressed, and a lot of other things that a total stranger should definitely *not* know.

Razz was saying something about a sword when Adora saw it.

Just to the right of the road was a small sign partially illuminated by the headlights of her car. It was a simple green road sign that read ' *Entering Greyskull* '.

Weird .

Maybe Adora had spelled the name wrong or something because surely this *very real town* would have shown up somewhere on google.

The road was lined with thick forestation and it took a moment for the actual town to come into sight.

When it did, Adora was greeted by the sight of a small main street lined with small family owned businesses. Not knowing where Razz lived, she decided to park on the side of the street. Surely there was somewhere Adora could bring Madame Razz to ensure she made it home safely.

By the time Adora parked and took the keys out of the ignition, Razz was already making her way across the street.

"Hey! Wait!" She called after Razz. It didn't look like it was a safety hazard, there were almost no cars on the road. The place was a ghost town, the only sign of life being the flashing lights of the so-called 'Brightmoon Diner' a few feet away.

Razz looked back, waiting for Adora to jog across the street before heading into the diner.

The chimes on the door announced their arrival. Adora looked over to see two women behind the counter, both with strawberry blonde hair that was more of a pink color than anything. Mother and daughter, she assumed.

Razz chose a booth on the far left side of the restaurant, a few rows back from the door. Adora had no other choice but to sit down across from her. If this was truly the small town she thought it was, maybe there was a patron or employee here who knew Razz's family.

Adora was examining the salt and pepper shakers on the table when she felt multiple pairs of eyes watching her.

The few patrons scattered about were looking at Adora as if she were a ghost. Did this town just not like visitors or something? When Adora looked up, they all averted their gaze quickly.

There wasn’t much time to think about the uneasy feeling in her stomach before their waitress made her way over.

Dressed in a vintage purple uniform with her hair swept to the side and a name tag that read ‘Glimmer’, their server began to hand out menus.

“There’s no need for that, dearie.” Razz kindly pushed the menus away. “We’ll just take two hot chocolates with cinnamon on top.”

The waitress, Glimmer, gave a small smile. “Of course, Razz.” And then she was off without even writing the order down.

Hot chocolate with cinnamon. Adora added it to her list of things this stranger knew about her that she definitely shouldn’t have known. Maybe it was a common thing to have hot chocolate with cinnamon, even if Adora had never met someone who liked their hot chocolate that way.

A few moments later, Glimmer came back and placed two mugs on the table. Razz began drinking hers immediately like having hot chocolate with total strangers from Boston was normal for her.

Their waitress, however, lingered by the table for a moment. She wrung her hands and rocked back and forth as if desperately

wanting to say something but was too nervous to get the words out.

"Are you new in town?" The waitress finally asked, looking to Adora but very obviously having trouble maintaining eye contact. Something was making her nervous and Adora couldn't figure out what it was.

"Uh, yeah." Adora laughed nervously and looked over to see Razz still sipping from her mug. "Not for long, though. I just have to bring her home."

Glimmer nodded, finding peace with Adora's words but not looking any less relieved.

"Do you know where her family is?" Adora asked, fiddling with the handle of the mug in front of her that she was yet to drink from.

"Oh… well, um," Glimmer began. "She's the mayor's grandmother. They live in the biggest house here, you'll know it when you see it."

Adora nodded, listening to the directions Glimmer gave as Razz wordlessly finished her cup of hot chocolate and reached across the table to steal Adora's.

Right as Glimmer started to turn and head back, Adora asked what she thought was a simple question.

"And who's the mayor?" Adora watched Glimmer stop dead in her tracks and turn to face her. The color had almost completely drained from her face. When she answered, her voice was barely above a whisper.

"Catra Mills."

The glass on the table was half-empty of gin and half-full of regret. Drinking wouldn't help, Catra knew that. But it was all she could do to get her mind off of the fact that Razz hadn't come home yet.

She was never gone this long. Usually when she disappeared, she talked to the neighbors or went to the diner. Catra was always so caught up in work that it didn't matter, everyone in town knew Razz and would always bring her home if need be. They were too scared of Catra to try anything else.

When she pulled the lever of the portal, this town was the absolute last thing Catra expected.

Not that she listened to Entrapta or Adora's warnings, but she thought they would at least just end up in an alternate reality on Etheria. When she woke up in the town of Greyskull, Maine where everyone else had no recollection of their past lives but her, things got complicated.

Bow, Glimmer, Perfuma, Scorpia, and everyone else here had absolutely no memory of anything that happened on Etheria. Princess alliances and magic powers were things they knew only from stories.

Catra could still remember the day she woke up tangled in silk sheets in this mansion, feeling nothing but absolute confusion.

This new world she found herself in was too normal, too perfect. Even now, Catra still didn't feel like she had adjusted.

The first time she saw Glimmer, she was prepared for a fight that never happened. Glimmer gave her a simple greeting, acting as if the two weren't just fighting on opposite sides of a war a few days ago.

At first, everyone's memories (or lack of) worked in Catra's favor. Everyone knew her as a mayor who was just intimidating, not Hordak's right hand man in the raging war between the Horde and the Rebellion. Everyone in the town of Greyskull was leading a life of lies and each one of them was completely oblivious to it all.

Everyone except for Madame Razz.

She had been a thorn in Catra's side since their first day here. By the first nightfall in town, Catra acquired a new level of confidence. She was in on something that no one else was. She had what she wanted - control, power.

That confidence was shattered when some random old lady showed up on her doorstep, accusing her of breaking the world.

Everywhere Razz went, chaos followed her. As it turns out, Catra and Razz were the only two people in Greyskull who had kept their memories. Catra didn't know then, but since Razz was stuck in the middle of the past and the present and able to keep her memories of both while she was on Etheria, the portal had no effect on her ability to remember her old life.

Not wanting to risk the other people in town uncovering the truth, Catra had Razz move in so she would be able to keep an eye on her. Razz happily obliged and made herself at home immediately. As far as everyone in town knew, Razz was just Catra's grandmother and her ramblings of Etheria were nothing but the result of illness and old age. No one believed her, but they did listen. The citizens of Greyskull liked Razz more than Catra, not that she cared (she did).

After a few days in this world, it was a pleasant surprise to learn that Adora was not a resident in the town of Greyskull. No one remembered her either, so it's not like Catra could ask where she was. Maybe she didn't make it through the portal, maybe she was

here but just not in Greyskull, Catra didn't care. Adora's absence meant that it was less likely for the town to be saved and brought back to Etheria and that was fine with Catra.

Throughout the years, she learned how to adjust and navigate this world. Everyone else's memories had been replaced by ones from their new life. Catra wasn't like everyone though, so she had to learn these things on her own.

Catra learned that food came in a much larger variety, none of which included grey or brown protein bars. There was something called a school a few blocks away, and everyone lived in neighborhoods instead of barracks. Being mayor really just meant having control of the town, which Catra had no problem getting used to.

Something Catra didn't count for was how lonely winning would feel.

It was a different kind of loneliness now that she was one of two people who knew the truth. She felt out so out of place, wrong, almost.

Catra got up from the table, not bothering to clean up the glass. Her thoughts were getting to her again, but how could they not be in this big, empty place?

She began pacing and debating the appropriate time to report Razz's disappearance. It had to be soon right?

Nightfall had come and gone and there was no sign of her. And as much as Catra hated to admit it, she did care about the woman's well being. Sue her.

Just as she went to reach for her keys, there was a knock at the door.

Finally, she thought.

Catra unlocked her door, already preparing her lecture for the woman on the other side.

"Jesus, Razz. I was starting to think-" Catra didn't finish her sentence.

There on her doorstep, with the same grey-blue eyes and blonde ponytail as always, was Adora.

Catra felt like she had just been slapped across the face. Every single word she could've said dissolved on her tongue, leaving a bitter aftertaste. After a few seconds, she had to remind herself to breathe.

Razz was on her doorstep, just as she expected. Adora was right beside her, something she very much did *not* expect.

Catra couldn't take her eyes off of her. She knew she looked ridiculous, she could see the confusion written all over Adora's face. It didn't matter, at least not in that moment. Because somehow, some way, Catra and Adora found each other again.

Razz looked between the two with the biggest grin on her face, clapping her hands excitedly.

"This is my favorite part!" Catra glared at Razz, but the woman didn't seem to care. She simply walked right into the foyer as if nothing had happened.

When Catra turned back around, Adora had extended her hand towards her.

"I'm Adora." She introduced herself, giving Catra a polite smile.

The two words broke her heart. Catra shouldn't be as hurt as she was, she knew what she was getting herself into when she pulled

that lever. As much as she didn't want to admit it, she didn't enjoy fighting Adora. Their past followed them everywhere they went, it hung in the air as a constant reminder of what they used to be. And even when they were fighting, Adora remembered the Horde and all the nights Catra slept at the end of her bed. There were still memories of promises, no matter how broken they were.

Now, there was nothing. Adora didn't remember Catra. To her, this was their first meeting. And Catra had no choice but to act the same way.

She eventually accepted Adora's hand, shaking it as she tried not to think about the fact that this was the first time in years Adora had touched Catra that wasn't while they were fighting.

It was the first time in years that they weren't meeting on a battlefield of some kind. Now it was just a simple front step in a different reality.

"Catra." She introduced herself. Catra couldn't remember the last time she did that with Adora. "Sorry about that. Come in." She stepped back and motioned into the foyer.

Adora smiled and walked into the home, accidentally brushing her arm against Catra's in the process.

"Sorry." She said. Catra tried to ignore the way her heart sped up at what was barely the ghost of a touch.

_____

"So," Adora began. "How long have you been mayor?"

Catra looked up from her drink, staring at Adora as if she were caught off guard by the question.

"Uh… a few years now." She answered after a moment. Adora nodded and took a sip of her cider. It wasn't a weird thing to ask the mayor how long they've been in office… right? Adora didn't seem to think so.

They had barely talked since Catra invited her in, which Adora didn't really understand. What's the point in having guests if you'll barely talk to them?

Madame Razz had gone upstairs, saying something about how she was going to let the two of them reconnect. Adora didn't know how exactly they would do that, considering they've never met before. But it wasn't a bad idea to take a break before driving home. The last few hours had been, well, exhausting.

"Are you here to stay?" Catra asked, playing with one of the buttons on her blouse.

“No, actually.” Adora said. “I just wanted to make sure Razz got home safely.”

Catra smiled. “That was very kind of you.”

A few minutes went by before either of them said anything.

“Well, it’s late. I should get going.” Adora got up from her chair, putting her coat on and grabbing her keys.

Catra gave a simple nod before following her to the door.

Adora was on the porch when she finally decided she would ask. It couldn’t hurt to make sure Razz was okay.

“Should I worry about Razz coming to visit me again? Boston is a long drive… not that I wouldn’t mind bringing her back!” Adora watched as Catra’s expression became unreadable. “It’s just… I wanna make sure she’s safe.”

When Adora didn’t hear a response, she looked up to see that Catra had almost closed the distance between the two. From here, Adora could see the freckles dusted across her nose and cheeks. She noticed the woman had two different colored eyes - one a deep amber and the other the color of oceans after a storm.

Even though she was a few inches shorter than Adora, Catra was most definitely intimidating. Not that Adora was intimidated or anything.

"I don't need you to worry about my grandmother. Really, it's none of your business." Catra bit out, her voice low and a threat clear behind her words. "You can go now."

Adora shook her head. Clearly there was something she was missing. Catra very obviously didn't like her, no matter how much she tried to hide behind table manners and common courtesies. Adora wasn't a total idiot, after all.

"Oh, um, of course." *Smooth.*

Adora turned around, more than ready to start walking away and never come back to this town and it's mayor. She was almost down the steps when-

"Adora?"

She turned around.

"Yes?"

“Don’t come back.”

_____

It was a clear warning. A *very* clear warning.

Adora was ignoring it anyways.

She got in her car and drove away as fast as the local speed limit allowed, feeling Catra’s lingering stare long after she was gone.

Adora was worried about Razz. Not just her wellbeing, but the fact that she was under the care of someone like Catra. She was definitely not staying out of spite.

(It was partially because of spite, but that’s besides the point.)

That was how Adora found herself at the Inn. It was a bed and breakfast, the other half being the diner she had been to earlier that day.

At the counter was their waitress from earlier. Glimmer, if Adora remembered correctly.

She looked at Adora with clear surprise written all over her face.

"Hi,"

"Hi! Can I help you with anything?" Glimmer asked politely.

"Yeah, actually. I'd like a room." Whatever semblance of normal conversation they had going on ended right then. Glimmer looked confused, as if she somehow forgot the bed part of the bed and breakfast.

"A room?"

"Yes?"

"Sorry," Glimmer laughed nervously, reaching under the counter and pulling out a key. "We haven't had anyone stay here in so long. You'll be in room seven."

Adora thanked her as she accepted the key, tracing her fingers over the number engraved in the cool metal. She half listened, half tuned out as Glimmer gave her the directions to her room and what time breakfast was and all of the other deals. As surprised as she had been, Glimmer seemed excited to welcome a new guest.

Adora turned to start towards her room.

"Could I ask how long you'll be staying with us?" Glimmer's voice was quieter and noticeably less excited than it had been just a few seconds ago. She sounded…. worried. Adora turned to face her.

"Just a day or so. Not too long."

_____

"I'm telling you! There *is* someone staying at the Inn!" Glimmer was doing her best to keep her voice down. Bow was on the other line, currently laughing his ass off.

"Are you serious?" He said once he was able to catch his breath.

The minute Glimmer heard Adora shut her door and not a second later, she picked up the phone to call Bow. Maybe it was her memory or her brain after a full day of work but Glimmer genuinely could not remember the last time someone new came to town.

The people in Greyskull were the same as they'd always been. No one came into town and no one left. There was never anyone

new. That was the way it'd always been.

Until now, apparently. Adora had come into town with Razz, stopped at the diner, and got a room. It was a welcome change, but it was most definitely not normal.

"Maybe Greyskull is becoming a tourist destination or something." Bow said over the phone and Glimmer could just *hear* the smirk in his voice.

"Bow, I swear to god-" As annoyed and confused as she was, Glimmer smiled as the sound of Bow's laughter filled the phone speaker once again.

"Listen, I'm leaving the office now. I'll stop over once I'm done." Bow said. He worked as a therapist right across the street from the diner. Glimmer was more than used to him coming over at the end of his day and hanging out for a bit before deciding to go home. It was nice and easily Glimmer's favorite part of the day.

"Sounds good."

"We need to talk."

The day after Adora came through town, Catra had decided she would pay someone a visit.

Entrapta nodded nervously, opening the door all the way to allow Catra entrance to the house.

As it turns out, getting exiled to Beast Island didn't stop the portal from bringing Entrapta through to Greyskull. It wasn't something Catra knew until today. She had control of city records, yes. But some part of her had always been afraid to check.

She and Entrapta weren't exactly friends, but it was a cruel thing to exile someone to Beast Island. In her anger, Catra didn't hesitate to do it. She thought she had finally gotten over it, that she had let it go. Catra had to adjust to the real world, and the real world didn't have a war between magical princesses and the horde.

Still, there was a lingering pang of guilt when Entrapta opened the door and Catra was face to face with bright purple pigtails and an oblivious smile.

Entrapta lived on a large outstate just on the outskirts of town. It was remote enough that you could find it when you wanted to, but it was hard to stumble upon otherwise. Inside was littered with a variety of bolts and tools and robots. It was almost comforting to see that nothing had changed.

Catra sat down on one of the plush couches, watching Entrapta do the same on the one across from her. The woman narrowed her eyes and cocked her head in confusion, taking a moment to evaluate Catra.

"Are you here to ask me about the portal?" Entrapta asked the question so plainly that Catra almost forgot that she was not supposed to know about that.

"I'm sorry, I- What?" Catra laughed as a result of her disbelief and how bluntly Entrapta stated the question.

"The portal." Entrapta said again, this time looking confused at Catra as if it was common knowledge. "It's the reason we're all here."

"You know about that?" Catra asked, her voice quiet from pure shock.

"Of course I do!" Entrapta clapped her hands excitedly. "I did conduct a few social experiments, so I know not everyone *does* know about it. I also did a lot of research while we were still on Etheria."

Catra blinked. In all the time they had been stuck here she never once thought to check in on Entrapta. She mentally kicked herself for that stupid decision.

“Then I need your help with something.” Catra didn’t expect Entrapta to help her, not after everything with Beast Island happened. Catra could only hope she would get the answers she came here for. “What would happen if, hypothetically, Adora came to town and was told about Etheria.”

Her last few words were rushed, as Catra was desperate to get them out and over with. Admitting that Adora was in Greyskull was admitting failure. It couldn’t be long before she somehow saved everyone *again* .

“First of all, she would have to believe in Etheria and the legends of She-Ra before anything else could happen.” Entrapta tapped her chin in thought before shrugging. “And if she somehow reconnects with the sword after that then the portal will open again and we will all go back to Etheria.”

The sword.

When Catra woke up in her house on the first day, it had been on her nightstand. She considered hanging it up on the wall or putting it in a glass case, like a trophy of sorta. She ended up locking it in a chest under her bed.

Everytime she looked into the blade of the sword, it was Adora’s face she saw staring back at her. Her grey eyes were filled with fear, just like they were before Catra pulled the lever. The memory

lingered, and the sword wasn't so much of a trophy as it was mocking Catra and the fact that she still missed Adora.

After a few more minutes of conversation, Catra knew everything she needed to know. Not that she would have to use the information, considering that Adora had probably left town by then. But it made her feel more comfortable to have just in case.

She got up and smoothed out the wrinkles from her dress pants, making up an excuse of how she should probably get back to work.

Catra didn't have to play nice here, she knew that. The only one to really keep her in check was herself. No one was about to tell the mayor what to do.

But as time went on and the reality of her victory set in, she couldn't help but feel like she didn't have to be the person she was on Etheria. Catra had been mean and cruel when she was fighting a war but now, she had everything she needed. She had power and control that she didn't have to fight for and she was *comfortable* .

"Entrapta?"

"Yes?" Entrapta had begun inspecting one of the bots on the coffee table, too engrossed in her work to make eye contact with Catra.

“I just wanted to say that I-” There were a lot of wrong ways to say this and Catra was painfully aware of that fact. She hated apologies, but she hated feeling guilty even more. “I’m sorry. For everything that happened on Etheria.”

Entrapta stopped tinkering with the bot to look up at Catra with wide eyes. Her expression faded from shock to something softer. She smiled.

“I forgive you.”

_____

The second day in town wasn’t too bad. Yes, Adora had promised herself she would stay just one day. But Greyskull was just so *nice* and she was getting bored of the city.

Since deciding to stay, Adora had begun to talk with the patrons that filtered in and out of the diner. They would ask about her past and how long she was planning to stay, seemingly very interested in the first visitor the town had seen in a while.

Adora didn’t mind it, though. The people were interesting and more diverse than she would have expected from such a small town.

She had talked more with Glimmer, which meant an eventual introduction to her friend, Bow, who worked as a therapist in the office across the street. There was also Perfuma, who taught second grade at the elementary school and came in every morning for tea. Scorpia came in every morning for coffee, but it was very obvious she planned her trip to the diner just to run into Perfuma.

For all this time Adora had spent talking with a good handful of people, she was yet to see the mayor again.

Just as she started to get ready for the day, there was a knock at the door. Adora made her way over, expecting the knock to belong to someone from housekeeping.

On the other side of the door, Adora was met with two mismatched eyes staring at her, waiting expectantly.

Catra was dressed in another silk blouse. One of many, Adora assumed. Her dress pants were free of wrinkles and her curls were held back with a simple headband.

Adora watched in confusion as Catra’s face darkened a few shades and she very obviously tried to compose herself.

“Shirt.” Catra cleared her throat, unable to hold eye contact with Adora any longer.

“What?”

“Could you put on a shirt?” At that, Adora looked down to see that she was dressed in only her leggings and sports bra.

What an idiot.

“Oh! Yeah, sorry.” Adora grabbed her shirt from where it was hanging on a chair in the room, throwing it on over her head without even checking to see if it was inside out. What kind of idiot answers the door when they aren’t even completely dressed? Adora, apparently.

When she made her way back to the door, Catra was still waiting with her arms crossed.

“Why are you still here?” Was all she asked.

“Why do you care?” Adora stepped closer, lowering her voice to meet Catra’s.

“Because I’m the mayor and I want to know.” Catra was very obviously not telling the complete truth.

“Is that it?” Too caught up in figuring out Catra’s motive, Adora had failed to realize how close they had gotten. Neither woman moved.

“I don’t think that’s for you to worry about, *Adora* .” The way Catra said her name sent a chill down Adora’s spine, one she was already planning to blame on the shitty heating system.

“But *you* seem awfully worried. Why?”

“Because you decided to stay after bringing *my* grandmother home and asking about her safety. Forgive me for not wanting a stranger in my family life.” Adora laughed at that, but there was more frustration and annoyance than humor.

“And what if I was? *Your* grandmother came all the way up to Boston to find someone she’d never met before so forgive *me* if I’m a little concerned.” Catra opened her mouth to say something before closing it again and Adora knew she had the upper hand.

“Thanks again for that.” The sentiment was undermined by Catra’s bitter tone. Adora decided to accept it anyways, doing so with the biggest shiteating grin on her face.

“You’re welcome.”

Catra scowled and looked Adora up and down before walking down the hall and right down the stairs.

It was only their second meeting but Adora couldn’t shake the familiarity of it. Yes, their time was mostly spent arguing. But the rhythm was comfortable, like they had spent a lifetime doing it.

Adora felt crazy for even letting herself think it. Familiarity? With a person she only just talked to for the second time? It sounded ridiculous.

Adora shut the door before grabbing her hair tie to pull her hair into it’s signature ponytail. With a deep breath, Adora finished getting dressed.

She could almost feel her heart speed up at the thought that she was definitely going to see Catra again today.

_____

Just knock. Adora wished it was only that simple.

She stood on the doorstep of the big white house with a box of pie in hand. Glimmer said there was no better apology than food, and Adora couldn't really disagree with that.

Not that she wanted to apologise to Catra since Adora wasn't entirely sure *what* she was apologizing for. But if Catra wasn't going to be the bigger person, that responsibility automatically fell on Adora.

This wasn't about Catra anyways. Adora could deal with the rude comments and glares. It was a small prince to pay to make sure that Razz was okay. Adora had barely seen her since the first night and she knew who's fault that was.

Adora raised her fist again, this time with enough courage to actually knock.

The door being answered took longer than expected. When it finally was, Catra did *not* look happy to see Adora on the other side.

"Hi, I-" Catra shut the door in Adora's face almost as soon as she had opened it.

Adora wanted to scream. It wouldn't be an appropriate thing to do, considering she was here to make amends. She knocked again.

“I come here to apologize and you shut the door on me?!” She yelled, sensing Catra still lingering on the other side. Adora knew she could hear her.

A few seconds later the door opened for the second time, the look on Catra’s face the same as the first time. She didn’t look any more relieved to see Adora still standing there, but she moved aside to welcome her nonetheless.

Adora walked into the grand foyer, immediately distracting herself with the large chandelier that hung above her head. It was such a nice house, but still depressing. There were no plants or colors besides white, black, and grey. It was painfully dull and smelled of cleaning product but maybe that was just how Catra liked it.

“What is that?” Adora looked down from the ceiling to see Catra now standing in front of her, pointing a finger at the box in her hands.

“Apology pie.” Adora answered simply. She really didn’t want to elaborate on it, but it was kind of inevitable considering Catra would most likely not let her see Razz unless she apologized first.

Catra’s brow furrowed in confusion. With a shrug, she accepted the pie from Adora’s hands.

Catra's breath hitching as her fingers brushed Adora's hand was surely a coincidence. Adora blamed her elevated heart rate on anxiety and that was the end of it.

Unsure of where to sit, Adora picked the same chair at the table she had been sitting in the other day. Catra disappeared into the kitchen, only to reappear with two glasses of cider and the slice of pie divided in half and placed on two separate plates. She wordlessly pushed a glass and accompanying plate towards Adora. While the pie wasn't supposed to be for Adora, the offering was clearly an olive branch, and she had no choice but to accept it.

"So-"

"You're here to see Razz. I know." Catra said bitterly, shoveling a piece of pie into her mouth.

"How do you know?" Adora's voice went up a few octaves. She didn't miss the grin that spread across Catra's lips.

"We aren't best friends or anything. What else would you be here for? A sleepover?" Adora laughed despite herself. If Catra wasn't so mean most of the time, she'd actually be funny.

“What if I just wanted to talk to you?” Adora teased. It got the reaction she desired, considering Catra almost choked on her pie. After the coughing fit ended, Catra responded.

“If you just wanted to talk to me, you wouldn’t try to kiss my ass with this piece of pie.” Catra’s voice was raspy from coughing. It made Adora a lot more nervous than it should’ve.

“I did come to check on Razz, but that’s besides the point.” Catra’s face was unreadable and it quite honestly scared the shit out of Adora. “I think we got off on the wrong foot. So it was less of a kiss-ass pie and more of a truce.”

Catra smiled a little at that before catching herself. She played with a piece of pie on her plate, staining it purple as she dragged the berries with her fork. She looked more serious than she had been a few seconds ago.

“Fine.” She bit out, not looking Adora in the eye. It was a start, at least.

Adora held her hand out over the table. It’s not like they would hug it out, so she decided the next best option was to shake on it.

“Promise?” Adora asked. It was a simple word, nothing more than a mutual understanding that they would stop coming at each other’s throats every five seconds. When she saw Catra’s head shoot up and her eyes go wide, Adora knew there was more to it

for her. She knew something was off, and not just with Catra, but she couldn't place exactly what it was.

"What did you just say?" Catra's voice was just barely above a whisper. Adora would've missed it if she wasn't anxiously awaiting the response.

"Sorry, I just thought we would promise to stop fighting. Is something wrong?" Catra blinked, seeming to regain some semblance of composure after Adora's explanation.

"Yeah, I- I guess that's fine." Catra agreed but made no move to accept Adora's hand. Catra didn't have to shake on it, Adora reminded herself.

She was about to retract her hand when the feeling of Catra's skin on hers made everything in the world come to a stop. Adora froze.

"I promise." Catra said. She shook Adora's hand, the touch lingering long after the handshake. With a glance down at their hands, Catra realized it was over and pulled her hand away, leaving a trail of fire on Adora's skin in its absence.

"I'll be right back." Catra got up from the table and began collecting the dishes before Adora could even offer to help. "Razz is upstairs." And it was over. What was supposed to be an agreement between the two had just left Adora with an empty

feeling she couldn’t put a name to. It wasn’t relief, that was for sure.

Adora watched as Catra disappeared into the kitchen before starting up the grand staircase.

Rinse, scrub, rinse. Rinse, scrub, rinse. Rinse, scrub, rinse.

No matter how hard Catra scrubbed the plates and glasses it wasn’t enough to stop the word from echoing in her mind over and over again.

“ *Promise?”*

It was a simple word, consisting of only seven letters. But it held enough weight and memories and tears from another lifetime that it had only opened up the gates Catra had spent years trying to close.

Her mind was back on Etheria. She wasn’t in Greyskull, washing dishes at her sink. She was back in the Horde, making pinky promises with her best friend and running through the hallways. If she focused hard enough, Catra could still feel Adora’s embrace.

The word meant nothing to Adora now. But in Catra's mind, it was always more than just a promise. It meant that Adora would skip dinner if Catra wasn't coming, or that she would let Catra sleep on her bed if she had another bad dream. That one word meant that Adora and Catra would always be together, in one life or another.

Hot tears fell down her face, stinging her cheeks as they went. It was true. It was still true. They had found each other again.

Adora had left her and fought in a war against Catra for years. Adora had broken almost every promise she ever made and she didn't even *remember* it.

The tears Catra shed weren't just for the memories of their life on Etheria. It was for the fact that Adora, *her* Adora, showed up on her doorstep with no memory of who Catra was.

There was no one to blame but herself. All Catra could do was make sure her sobs were quiet enough to not alert anyone else in the house.

The dishes had been clean for a while. There was no point in continuing to wash them. Catra could wash the plates and glasses a million times over, it didn't matter. It was never going to make herself forget. It was never going to make Adora remember.

"I'm fine, dearie! You really have to stop worrying so much, Mara."

"I told you before, I'm not Mara." Adora smiled. Whoever Mara was, she obviously meant a lot to Razz.

The first bedroom Adora had passed in the hallway undoubtedly belonged to Razz. The walls were painted a deep purple color and there was a whole wall of bookshelves. There were chairs and a desk littered with papers and books, everything in the room matching shades of purple, green, and pink.

Razz had been sitting in a velvet green armchair by the bookshelves, reading a book. She was glad to see Adora and immediately invited her to sit in the chair opposite her own.

The first thing Adora did once she sat down was ask if Razz was okay. The woman seemed absolutely fine, but there was no harm in asking.

"How is Catra?" Razz raised an eyebrow knowingly at Adora, very obviously hinting at something.

"We made up." Adora thought about the promise, the handshake, Catra's rushed exit. "At least, I think so."

“Good! When we get back to Etheria, you’ll have to stop the war.” Razz picked up two large knitting needles from the table beside her and started working with a ball of light green yarn.

“Why is there a war?” Adora didn’t know if it was the right thing to be asking. It was probably better to not play into this false reality that Razz believed in. But she couldn’t help her curiosity.

“Why is there ever war? One side wants land and power and the other wants peace.” Razz shrugged. The answer was vague enough that Adora didn’t press.

“And why am I fighting in the war?”

“Because you are She-Ra! You were raised by the Horde, but you left them to fight with the princesses.” Razz looked up from her knitting to talk about She-Ra. It seemed thrilling, or at least it would if it was real.

Adora started to ask another question when her vision went white. The splitting headache came out of nowhere, the pain causing her to shut her eyes tight and bring her hands to her head.

Flashes of colorful visions danced across her eyelids. She was reaching for a sword before the light filled her vision once more.

The next one was of Catra with ears and a tail that bore strong resemblance to that of a cat's. There was smoke and soldiers scattered around them. Adora reached out. The white light came again. Adora looked down to see Glimmer and Bow at her side, both dressed in armor. They were smiling up at Adora. There was another flash of white and then it was over.

Adora opened her eyes. She was still in Razz's room, never having left the chair. The only change was that Razz was right in front of her, looking concerned as ever.

"Are you getting the flashes?" Razz whispered.

Adora could lie to herself all day long. She could say it was dizziness, deja vu, or whatever other excuse she could think of. There was no denying that this was real.

Razz wasn't lying. She had never lied once about Etheria or the princesses or any of it. She was always telling the truth and Adora had been foolish to not believe her.

This town was always too weird, too perfect. Adora could remember the gut feeling she had the moment her car passed over town lines. That had been a very long and very weird night, there were a million things she could've felt off about.

But now, *Adora remembered* .

There was another flash. This time, Catra looked back at Adora with a grin on her face as she pulled a lever. There was something holding Adora back, something she was tied to. She could feel herself screaming, but there was no sound.

When Adora opened her eyes again, Razz was holding her hands, the cool metal of the rings helping to ground Adora and bring her back to reality.

“This isn’t real, is it?” Adora asked, watching Razz slowly shake her head in response. All of the pieces were falling into place. She thought about everything Razz said from the moment she barged into Adora’s apartment to now. It all made sense.

The portal. That’s why they were here.

When Catra pulled the lever, it brought them to an alternate universe where none of them remembered who they were. Everyone had fake memories of a fake life. Everyone except Razz and-

“Does Catra know?” Razz nodded again.

Adora couldn’t breathe. There was plenty of oxygen in the air, but none of it was enough to fill her lungs. The room was spinning, the flashes still fresh in her mind.

Adora filed through the memories. She could remember fighting alongside Bow and Glimmer and the battlefield where she left Catra. There was something else…. something about a sword.

If Catra still had her memories and knew about the portal, she had to know where the sword was. Adora got up from the chair and excused herself from the room. She needed to calm down, but she also needed answers.

The *audacity* Catra had to act like everything was normal. She should've known something was off with how she reacted to Adora inciting a promise. But no, Catra was mean and invited Adora inside and accepted the fucking pie all while she remembered Adora.

She was halfway down the hall when she realized that she actually didn't know where she was going. There was a door further up and to her right and when she tried the handle, it opened.

The bedroom was a blur of maroon and black and Adora knew immediately who it belonged to. She shouldn't be doing this, and that fact only made her want to do it even more. Adora would check in the room for any clues she could find. Worst case scenario would be if Catra found out, but she didn't need to know that Adora remembered anything.

There was a single strip of sun streaming into the room from a gap in the black curtains. Something on the plush carpet caught the light, so faint that Adora would've missed it if she wasn't looking for something just like it.

She checked to make sure no one was behind her before going into the room and reaching for whatever was peeking out from under the bed.

It was a long chest that was beautifully crafted, made of wood and accented with metal designs. Whatever was in here must be important.

Catra probably left the chest unlocked by accident, since Adora was successfully able to open it. She lifted the top of the chest slowly, catching a glimpse of the velvet interior and a faint glow from the inside.

With one quick motion, like ripping off a bandaid, Adora opened the chest the rest of the way.

Inside, nestled on top of a velvet cushion, was a sword.

No, not just a sword.

Adora's sword.

The metal was cleaned and polished. It looked much cleaner than it had been in Adora's possession. The gold handle looked the same, as well as the runestone at the center. There was a faint glow emanating from the sword and if Adora looked hard enough she could see the First Ones writing engraved on the blade.

She unconsciously brought her hand up to reach for the sword, something that had been second nature to her not that long ago. Just as her fingers were about to touch the cool metal, there was pressure on her back and Adora was being knocked to the ground before she was able to defend herself.

If the sight of Catra above her wasn't enough to make Adora lose her breath, her back hitting the floor definitely was. Catra straddled her waist, pinning her to the ground with both hands on Adora's wrists.

A few years ago this would have been normal for them. Catra would've tackled Adora to the ground and help her up as they fought for breath after laughing so hard. Now, it was a clear fight.

Catra was strong, but Adora was able to push her arms off of the floor and flip them around so that they had now switched positions.

"What did you do?!" Adora knew the answer. They both did, they both knew what happened. Adora searched the gold and blue eyes beneath her for an explanation as to *why* .

Catra didn’t answer, instead trying and failing to fight her way out of Adora’s grip. There were a million questions flooding Adora’s mind and she had no idea how to say any of them.

“You didn’t have to pull the lever. That couldn’t have been what you really wanted, Catra.” Adora saw a flash of an emotion she couldn’t name in Catra’s eyes. She didn’t seem surprised that Adora remembered.

“And what if it was?” Catra countered. She had stopped fighting against Adora’s hold, but by the tone of her voice, she was not ready to admit defeat.

Adora leaned in close, moving so her lips were close enough to Catra’s ear that she would hear her next words and listen.

“ *We both know that’s not true* .” Adora had let her guard down for a fraction of a second and it was enough for Catra to force Adora off of her and start towards the chest across the room.

The next few seconds were a mess of tangled limbs as the two tried to fight to get to the sword. Adora was almost to the sword when she looked back to see that Catra had stopped fighting. She sat on the floor, her knees to her chest and her back turned towards Adora.

It crossed her mind that it was probably a trick to get Adora to stop fighting and give Catra the advantage, but she didn’t care.

Adora got up and walked to Catra, leaving the sword on the floor behind her.

She lowered herself to the ground once more, awkwardly sitting in front of Catra and debating whether or not she should say something.

“You won.” Catra said, lifting her head from her knees. Her eyes were red and her laugh had not a trace of humor in it. “You fucking won! What are you waiting for?”

Adora was stunned into silence. Catra was sitting on the floor in front of her, accepting her loss and not making a move to do anything about it. She was crying and no matter how hard Adora tried to be glad she found the sword, it didn’t make her feel any better.

This wasn’t winning in Adora’s eyes, not when Catra was so upset on the floor in front of her. The last few years had been spent trying to get Catra to come with her, to join Adora in the rebellion. Because while Adora knew she was on the right side, she wasn’t where she belonged. She belonged with Catra. She always would.

“You can come with me, you know. You don’t have to stay with the Horde.” Adora fought to keep her voice even because even though Catra might think so, she took no joy in seeing Catra like this.

“Stop pretending, Adora. I know you hate me.” Catra’s tone was bitter. She said this like it was common knowledge, like Adora’s offer was nothing but a trick. The fact that Catra thought that Adora would ever be able to hate her broke her heart.

“I never hated you.” Catra looked at Adora as if she’d never seen her before. She looked as if she were about to say something before deciding to hold herself back. Adora knew her words changed things between them, but she didn’t regret them at all. She considered that Catra could be mad at her, and Adora almost thought she was going to tackle her again when Catra started to lean forward.

Instead, Catra closed the distance between them and kissed her.

The kiss was desperate and messy. Both of their faces were stained with tears and they held each other as if they were the last people on Earth. Adora was holding Catra’s face in her hands and they fit as if that was the only thing they were made for. There was nowhere else in the universe that Adora was supposed to be but here in Catra’s arms. It wasn’t perfect by any means, both of them were such a mess.

Adora wouldn’t trade it for the world.

When they pulled away, they stayed in each other’s arms with the biggest smiles on their faces. And for the first time in years, Adora hugged Catra.

Catra clung to Adora like she was gravity, as if she was the only thing keeping Catra on Earth.

"I want to go home." Catra said, her voice muffled by Adora's shoulder.

"We will."

"Promise?" Adora smiled at the familiar question. What waited for them back on Etheria terrified her. Even if they had made up, there was still a war to fight. They still had a lot to talk about and apologies to make. But as long as she was with Catra, Adora knew she was right where she needed to be.

"I promise."

End Notes

god i love them so much

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!